



OFFICIAL PRESS CONFERENCE STATEMENT

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

Date: 01 June 2026
Venue: Birchwood Hotel, Boksburg
Issued By: Cde Banele Mnisi Spokesperson For Shosholoza Progressive Party (SHOSH)

SHOSHOLOZA PROGRESSIVE PARTY STATEMENT ON ITS TEMPORARY WITHDRAWAL FROM THE CONFERENCE OF THE LEFT

Members of the media, representatives of political organizations, comrades, supporters, and fellow South Africans,

Shosholoza Progressive Party wishes to provide clarity regarding the circumstances that led to our temporary withdrawal from the recent Conference of the Left held at Birchwood Hotel. Given the public interest surrounding this matter, we believe it is important to communicate our position openly, honestly, and responsibly.

We as Shosholoza Progressive Party entered the Conference of the Left in good faith and with a sincere commitment to the ideals of progressive politics, social justice, economic transformation, worker empowerment, youth development, and the building of a united left movement capable of addressing the challenges facing South Africa today.

Our participation in the conference was motivated by the belief that progressive organizations have a responsibility to engage in meaningful dialogue and collective action aimed at confronting poverty, unemployment, inequality, corruption, and the continued marginalization of working-class communities. We remain committed to these objectives and continue to believe that unity among progressive forces is both necessary and desirable.

However, unity cannot be achieved at the expense of principle. It cannot be built upon silence in the face of actions or associations that may undermine the values that progressive movements claim to uphold. It is for this reason that the Shosholoza Progressive Party found itself compelled to raise serious concerns during the proceedings of the conference.

During discussions, our President, Dr. Russon, formally objected to the involvement and association of the uMkhonto weSizwe Party (MKP) with an organization known as March and March. The objection was not raised lightly, nor was it intended to create division within the conference. Rather, it was motivated by a genuine concern regarding the implications of associating progressive political formations with activities and rhetoric that could be interpreted as encouraging or normalizing violence among black communities.

Dr. Russon expressed the view that any organization perceived to be promoting black-on-black violence stands in direct contradiction to the values of peace, solidarity, community development, and human dignity that should define the progressive movement. The history of South Africa teaches us painful lessons about the devastating consequences of political violence. As a nation, we have witnessed how violence among oppressed communities has often served to weaken struggles for liberation and social justice.

In particular, Dr. Russon highlighted concerns that certain actions and conduct associated with March and March bear troubling similarities to patterns that characterized some of the darkest periods in our democratic transition. He cautioned delegates that South Africans have not forgotten the tragic events of the early 1990s, a period marked by intense political conflict, instability, and violence.

Among the painful memories of that era is the Boipatong Massacre, in which 45 innocent people lost their lives. The massacre remains one of the most tragic and traumatic episodes in South Africa's history. It serves as a reminder of the human cost of political violence and the dangers of allowing divisions and hostility to escalate unchecked.

Dr. Russon emphasized that progressive organizations must remain vigilant against any developments that could revive the conditions that led to such tragedies. He argued that the Conference of the Left should be a platform for advancing democratic engagement, political education, peaceful mobilization, and constructive activism—not a platform where organizations linked to violent conduct are tolerated without scrutiny.

Accordingly, Dr. Russon called upon the MK Party leadership to clearly and unequivocally distance itself from March and March. He stated that such a declaration would help reassure conference participants, supporters, and the broader public that all organizations participating in the Conference of the Left remain committed to peaceful political engagement.

The request was straightforward. It was not intended as an attack on any particular political party. Rather, it was a call for clarity, accountability, and commitment to non-violence.

Unfortunately, during the discussions that followed, the spokesperson representing the MK Party declined to distance the organization from March and March. This response failed to address the concerns that had been raised and left significant questions unanswered.

The refusal to provide such assurance created a situation in which Shosholozza Progressive Party felt unable to continue participating in the conference under the prevailing circumstances. As a result, and after careful consideration, our delegation made the difficult decision to withdraw from the proceedings.

This decision was not made out of hostility toward any organization represented at the conference. Nor was it intended to undermine the broader objectives of left unity. Rather, it was a principled stand rooted in our commitment to non-violence, democratic values, and responsible political conduct.

We believe that political organizations have an obligation to draw clear lines when concerns arise regarding violence or the promotion of violence. Remaining silent in such circumstances would have been inconsistent with our principles and our responsibility to our members and supporters.

Following our withdrawal, efforts were made by several leaders and delegates to engage with the Shosholoza Progressive Party in order to address the concerns that had been raised. Among those who engaged with our leadership was Comrade Solly Mapaila (General Secretary Of SACP), who held discussions with representatives of our party.

During these engagements, Comrade Mapaila acknowledged the seriousness of the concerns and encouraged the Shosholoza Progressive Party to return to the conference in the interest of maintaining dialogue and preserving the broader project of left cooperation. Importantly, he provided assurances that the issues raised by Dr. Russon would receive attention and that efforts would be made to seek an appropriate resolution.

In the spirit of constructive engagement and collective responsibility, Shosholoza Progressive Party agreed to return to the conference. This decision was taken because we remain committed to dialogue and because we recognize the importance of creating spaces where progressive organizations can engage one another, even when disagreements arise.

Our return should not be interpreted as an abandonment of our concerns. On the contrary, it reflects our belief that political differences are best addressed through open discussion, transparency, and principled engagement.

At the same time, we wish to make it clear that our continued participation in the Conference of the Left cannot be taken for granted. The issues that prompted our withdrawal remain unresolved, and we expect meaningful action to be taken to address them.

We as Shosholoza Progressive Party will closely monitor developments and evaluate the responses of all parties involved. We believe that organizations claiming to represent progressive values must demonstrate those values not only through words but through actions. There must be a clear commitment to peaceful political engagement, respect for human life, and the rejection of any conduct that could contribute to violence or social instability.

Our position remains guided by several fundamental principles:

- **First**, we reject political violence in all its forms.
- **Second**, we reject any attempt to normalize violence as a legitimate tool of political expression.
- **Third**, we believe that progressive politics must be rooted in democracy, accountability, and respect for human dignity.
- **Fourth**, we support unity among left and progressive organizations, but only on the basis of shared values and mutual respect.
- **Fifth**, we believe that the interests of South Africa's working class, unemployed youth, and marginalized communities are best served by organizations that prioritize peace, development, and social transformation.

Shosholoza Progressive Party remains committed to building a society characterized by economic justice, social equality, and genuine empowerment for all South Africans. Our participation in progressive forums and alliances will always be guided by these principles.

We therefore call upon all organizations participating in the Conference of the Left to engage in honest reflection regarding the concerns that have been raised. We encourage meaningful dialogue, transparency, and decisive action where necessary. The credibility of the progressive movement depends upon its ability to uphold the values it claims to represent.

As matters currently stand, Shosholoza Progressive Party is continuing to observe developments closely. We await the resolution of the issues that were raised and reserve the right to make further pronouncements regarding our future involvement in the Conference of the Left should these concerns remain unresolved.

We wish to assure our members, supporters, and the South African public that every decision taken by our leadership is guided by principle rather than expediency. We will continue to stand firmly for peace, democracy, social justice, and the advancement of the people of South Africa.

The future of the progressive movement must be built on unity, but it must also be built on accountability. It must be built on solidarity, but it must also be built on principle. These are values that we as Shosholoza Progressive Party will continue to defend without compromise.

We thank the media and the public for their attention and remain available for further engagement on this matter.

Issued by:



Cde Banele Mnisi

Spokesperson For Shosholoza Progressive Party (SHOSH)

Contact Number: 069 389 1595 (Cde Banele Mnisi)

"Building a Just, Democratic and Prosperous South Africa Through Progressive Unity."